Project Planning Activity **Stat 495**

This project spans the rest of our time for the semester. That's about 4 weeks of class time. The deliverables are focused on assisting you with the "new" aspect of the project – researching and writing up an exposition on a new statistical topic. Yet you also need to have the second component – either an example application or a simulation study. You all have experience with the application idea from past projects. For the simulation study, our brief look at those Friday should have given you some ideas about what sorts of things need to be undertaken for that (see list or ask me!).

You have other classes and commitments to build into a realistic timeline for yourself as well. We want to try to build a timeline looking holistically over the end of your semester. Use the questions below and the calendar pages to help you get a sense of what things look like for your semester. If you already use an electronic calendar and want to use that instead, feel free.

1. Put the major deadlines below into the calendar so you can see the pacing for class deliverables.

Project Proposal Due by midnight on Wednesday, Nov. 5th (Gradescope)
Annotated Bibliography Due by midnight on Thursday, Nov. 13th (Gradescope)
Exposition Draft Due by midnight on Friday, Nov. 21st (Gradescope)
Exposition Discussions during the Week of Dec. 1st
Draft for Peer Review by midnight on Friday, Dec. 5th (pdf in repo)
Check-in by midnight on Wednesday, Dec. 10th (repo)
Final Report (and all remaining deliverables) by midnight on Monday, Dec. 15th (Gradescope)
Reflection Discussion on Wednesday or Thursday December 17th or 18th

2. What other major assignments do you have for your other classes? Put in what information you know about them. For example, do you have exam dates? Presentations? Etc.

3. Put in what your other final exams/final assignments are so you know what your reading period / finals week looks like. (The exam schedule is out.)

4. Are there other major extracurricular activities that you know will occupy a lot of time or you want to acknowledge in this planning process? Put anything else in the calendar that you want to have at the forefront of your mind.

5. Depending on which way you think you are going for the second component, list several pieces that would make sense to have your own deadline for. You can imagine this is things like: picking a data set, wrangling the data set, etc. for an application and for a simulation, figuring out the setting and parameters to vary, drafting the code, etc. Don't put these in the calendar yet.

6. Are you planning to work on the project over Thanksgiving break? This is not required, but some of you may want to decide about this to plan your time / travels, etc.

7. Identify any major patterns in your calendar. Are there days you expect you will always work on the project? Always have like a 2 hour work period for it? Are you more likely to have one-hour work periods? Knowing this can help you plan what you can accomplish in the time frame.

8. Go back to the list in #5 and try to see where those components might fit in your plan / calendar.

9. From discussion with many of you regarding the last project, I wanted to point out some items that you might want to put on the calendar, or adjust other personal deadlines for, so you can spend the time you hope to on them. That includes:

- Proofreading time
- Time to check over your pdf for proper code formatting
- Setting aside the 2-4 hours to review a peer's project on the weekend of Dec. 6th.
- Time to check out the paper template (coming).
- Time organizing files in your repo.

Anything else you can think of like this you want to include? Incorporate ones you are interested in into your calendar.

Advice: There are two pieces of advice I want to share as you embark on the project.

The first is that you should beware of the "iteration trap". Once you draft a section, it's possible to edit, and edit, and edit, and never move onto the next thing. To combat this, a strategy I've seen in the past is to adopt a 25%, 50%, 75%, and 90% framework. When looking at the overall project, you want to keep pieces roughly balanced. That is, if something is at 75%, and everything else is at 25%, you want to work on the 25% pieces and not iterate on the 75% piece to get it to 90% until the other pieces are further along. Doing this is easier said than done, but I wanted to put it out there.

The second is that it's a good idea to always have more than one aspect of the project to work on. This is because we naturally get bored / frustrated as humans and sometimes don't feel like working on something, so we want to have options. For example, if you plan a 2 hour writing session for the project but sit down and really aren't in a writing mood, already having another idea of what to work on could help. Here, you have two main components for the paper – the exposition and your application or simulation study. It's worth having an idea of something to work on for each running alongside each other. There are also "small" items you can do when you have a few minutes but don't feel like doing something major:

- Get sources into bibtex and into the template.
- Skim over a literature source you haven't included yet but plan to.
- Check the current rendered pdf for formatting issues / figure titles, etc.
- Check out your repo organization / commit/push.
- Outline a section or write down a few next goals / steps to work on later.

These don't need to go in a calendar but I wanted to give you ideas for how you can be productive with the project even if you only can devote 15 minutes to it during one particular working session.